



THE HOME IMPROVEMENT & RENOVATION RECORD KIT

Document it before you need to prove it.

Every project, from first estimate to final invoice: scope, bids, contractors, payments, change orders, materials, permits, photos, and the warranty on the work - one file per project, kept for good.

PROJECT RECORDS - 2026

How to Use This Kit

A renovation produces two things: the work, and the paper. The work stays on the wall; the paper scatters - estimates in email, receipts in a truck, the permit in a drawer. This kit gives every project one home. One project, one module: scope, bids, contractor, money, log, materials, photos, permits, completion.

OPEN THE FILE BEFORE THE WORK STARTS.

The scope worksheet and estimate grid do their job before anyone swings a hammer. A project documented from day one never has a missing beginning.

RECORD MONEY THE DAY IT MOVES.

Every payment, every change order, every materials receipt - logged the same day, with where the paper lives.

PHOTOGRAPH BEFORE DEMOLITION.

The 'before' photo can only be taken once. Everything else in the project can be reconstructed; the before cannot.

WHAT THIS KIT IS - AND IS NOT

This kit is a documentation and organization tool for your own project records. It is not legal, insurance, tax, or financial advice, does not verify any contractor's license or insurance, and does not interpret any contract. It records what happened, when, for how much, and where the proof lives.

Make it official

THIS RECORD STARTED (DATE)	KEPT BY	PROPERTY

Master Project Index

One line per project. As each project opens, give it a number and carry that number onto every page you use for it.

#	PROJECT	STARTED	COMPLETED	TOTAL COST	CONTRACTOR / SELF

01

Planning & Scope

What the project is - written down before anyone prices it. A clear scope is the reference point every later question comes back to.

IN THIS SECTION

- Scope worksheet
- What's included / excluded
- Estimate comparison grid
- Decision record

Scope Worksheet

PROJECT # / NAME

AREA(S) OF HOME

GOAL - WHAT DONE LOOKS LIKE

Work included

Explicitly NOT included

TARGET START

TARGET FINISH

BUDGET CEILING

Estimate Comparison

Same scope shown to each bidder. Note what each estimate actually covers - the cheapest number and the smallest scope often travel together.

	BID A	BID B	BID C
COMPANY			
TOTAL PRICE			
LABOR			
MATERIALS			
TIMELINE			
STARTS WHEN			
PAYMENT TERMS			
WARRANTY OFFERED			
IN WRITING? (Y/N)			
GUT READ (1-5)			

SELECTED BID & WHY

DECISION DATE

Contractor Record

Who is doing the work - documented, not assumed. Copy license and insurance details from the documents the contractor provides, and note the date you saw them.

IN THIS SECTION

- Contractor information cards
- License & COI documented
- References contacted

Contractor Cards - Page 1

CONTRACTOR 1

COMPANY / NAME		TRADE
PHONE	EMAIL	ADDRESS
LICENSE # (AS PROVIDED)	COI SEEN (DATE)	POLICY EXPIRES
REFERENCES CONTACTED (WHO / DATE)		
DOCUMENTS ON FILE: ESTIMATE [] CONTRACT [] COI [] W-9 [] WARRANTY []		

CONTRACTOR 2

COMPANY / NAME		TRADE
PHONE	EMAIL	ADDRESS
LICENSE # (AS PROVIDED)	COI SEEN (DATE)	POLICY EXPIRES
REFERENCES CONTACTED (WHO / DATE)		
DOCUMENTS ON FILE: ESTIMATE [] CONTRACT [] COI [] W-9 [] WARRANTY []		

Contractor Cards - Page 2

CONTRACTOR 3

COMPANY / NAME		TRADE
PHONE	EMAIL	ADDRESS
LICENSE # (AS PROVIDED)	COI SEEN (DATE)	POLICY EXPIRES
REFERENCES CONTACTED (WHO / DATE)		
DOCUMENTS ON FILE: ESTIMATE [] CONTRACT [] COI [] W-9 [] WARRANTY []		

CONTRACTOR 4

COMPANY / NAME		TRADE
PHONE	EMAIL	ADDRESS
LICENSE # (AS PROVIDED)	COI SEEN (DATE)	POLICY EXPIRES
REFERENCES CONTACTED (WHO / DATE)		
DOCUMENTS ON FILE: ESTIMATE [] CONTRACT [] COI [] W-9 [] WARRANTY []		

Agreement & Money

The contract facts, every payment, and every change - logged the day the money moves. This section is the financial memory of the project.

IN THIS SECTION

- Contract facts
- Payment ledger
- Change order log
- Invoice tracker

Contract Facts

THE AGREEMENT

PROJECT #	CONTRACT DATE	CONTRACT PRICE
PARTIES (AS WRITTEN)		
PAYMENT SCHEDULE (SUMMARY)		
START DATE PER CONTRACT	COMPLETION PER CONTRACT	ALLOWANCES (Y/N)
ORIGINAL KEPT WHERE	SIGNED COPY TO YOU (DATE)	

RECORD, THEN COMPARE

When dates or amounts change later, this page is what they changed from. Log the changes in the change-order pages - never overwrite the original facts.

Payment Ledger - Page 1

DATE	PROJECT #	PAID TO	FOR	METHOD	AMOUNT	RECEIPT WHERE

PAGE TOTAL _____

Payment Ledger - Page 2

DATE	PROJECT #	PAID TO	FOR	METHOD	AMOUNT	RECEIPT WHERE

PAGE TOTAL _____

Payment Ledger - Page 3

DATE	PROJECT #	PAID TO	FOR	METHOD	AMOUNT	RECEIPT WHERE

PAGE TOTAL _____

Change Order Log

Any change to scope, price, or schedule - however small, however verbal it started. Date it, price it, note who agreed.

DATE	PROJECT #	CHANGE (WHAT & WHY)	COST + / -	AGREED BY	IN WRITING?

Invoice Tracker

DATE REC'D	PROJECT #	FROM	INVOICE #	AMOUNT	PAID (DATE)	KEPT WHERE

Project Log

The running diary of the job: who was on site, what got done, what got found. Two minutes at the end of each work day - the page nobody regrets keeping.

IN THIS SECTION

- Dated running entries
- Crew on site
- Work performed & issues found
- Photo confirmation

Project Log - Page 1

DATE	PROJ #	ON SITE	WORK DONE / ISSUES FOUND / DECISIONS MADE	PHOTOS

Project Log - Page 2

DATE	PROJ #	ON SITE	WORK DONE / ISSUES FOUND / DECISIONS MADE	PHOTOS

Project Log - Page 3

DATE	PROJ #	ON SITE	WORK DONE / ISSUES FOUND / DECISIONS MADE	PHOTOS

Project Log - Page 4

DATE	PROJ #	ON SITE	WORK DONE / ISSUES FOUND / DECISIONS MADE	PHOTOS

Project Log - Page 5

DATE	PROJ #	ON SITE	WORK DONE / ISSUES FOUND / DECISIONS MADE	PHOTOS

Project Log - Page 6

DATE	PROJ #	ON SITE	WORK DONE / ISSUES FOUND / DECISIONS MADE	PHOTOS

Project Log - Page 7

DATE	PROJ #	ON SITE	WORK DONE / ISSUES FOUND / DECISIONS MADE	PHOTOS

Project Log - Page 8

DATE	PROJ #	ON SITE	WORK DONE / ISSUES FOUND / DECISIONS MADE	PHOTOS

Materials & Selections

What exactly went into the house - the model numbers, finishes, and suppliers you will otherwise be guessing at in five years.

IN THIS SECTION

- Selections register
- Supplier & cost
- Delivery & receipt location

Selections Register - Page 1

ITEM	SPEC / MODEL / COLOR	SUPPLIER	COST	DELIVERED	RECEIPT WHERE

Selections Register - Page 2

ITEM	SPEC / MODEL / COLOR	SUPPLIER	COST	DELIVERED	RECEIPT WHERE

Selections Register - Page 3

ITEM	SPEC / MODEL / COLOR	SUPPLIER	COST	DELIVERED	RECEIPT WHERE

Photo Record

Before, during, after - per area. The before photo can only be taken once; the during photos are the only record of what is now inside the walls.

IN THIS SECTION

- Per-area photo checklist
- Inside-the-walls shots
- Photo log with storage location

Photo Checklist - By Area

One row per area touched by the project. 'During' means open walls, rough plumbing, wiring, framing - the shots that disappear behind drywall.

AREA	BEFORE	DURING - OPEN WALLS	AFTER	STORED AT / ALBUM

Photo Log

DATE	PROJ #	WHAT THE PHOTOS SHOW	COUNT	ALBUM / FOLDER

Permits & Inspections

The official paper trail: what was permitted, what was inspected, and where the certificates live.

IN THIS SECTION

- Permit register
- Inspection log
- Certificates & final sign-offs

Permit Register

PERMIT #	PROJECT #	SCOPE OF PERMIT	ISSUED	FINAL'D	DOCUMENT WHERE

Inspection Log

DATE	TYPE	INSPECTOR / JURISDICTION	RESULT	NOTES / CORRECTIONS

08

Completion & Warranty

How the project ends on paper: the walkthrough, the punch list, the final documents, and the warranty on the work - recorded while everyone still answers the phone.

IN THIS SECTION

- Punch list
- Completion record
- Warranty handoff
- Closing document checklist

SECTION 08

Punch List

#	ITEM TO COMPLETE / CORRECT	RAISED	DONE	VERIFIED BY

Completion & Warranty Record

COMPLETION

PROJECT #

FINAL WALKTHROUGH DATE

PRESENT

FINAL PAYMENT DATE

FINAL AMOUNT

TOTAL PROJECT COST

PUNCH LIST CLEARED (DATE)

WARRANTY ON THE WORK

WARRANTY TERM

STARTS

ENDS

WHAT IT COVERS (SUMMARY)

WARRANTY DOCUMENT KEPT WHERE

CLAIM CONTACT

Closing documents received

- ☐ Final invoice marked paid
- ☐ Warranty in writing
- ☐ Permit final / certificate
- ☐ Manuals & spec sheets for installed items
- ☐ Leftover materials list (paint codes, tile lot #s)

Project Archive

Close the loop: where the project file lives, and the one-card summary that carries into your master property record.

IN THIS SECTION

- Where the file lives
- Summary card for the master record

Archive & Master-Record Summary

PAPER FILE LOCATION

DIGITAL FOLDER / ALBUM

Copy this summary into the Improvements section of your master property record (Kit 1, Section 09) so the whole-home record stays current.

PROJECT SUMMARY 1

PROJECT	AREA	
COMPLETED (DATE)	TOTAL COST	CONTRACTOR / SELF
WARRANTY ENDS	FILE LOCATION	

PROJECT SUMMARY 2

PROJECT	AREA	
COMPLETED (DATE)	TOTAL COST	CONTRACTOR / SELF
WARRANTY ENDS	FILE LOCATION	

When the Project Is Over

The week the project ends is the last week the record is easy to complete. Numbers are remembered, receipts are findable, and the contractor still answers. Spend one hour closing the file properly.

The close-out hour

- ☐ Payment ledger totaled and matched to invoices
- ☐ Change orders all logged with final costs
- ☐ After photos taken for every area
- ☐ Warranty and final documents filed and location noted
- ☐ Summary card copied to the master property record
- ☐ Whole file scanned - one digital copy offsite

PLAIN-LANGUAGE NOTE

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Document it before you need to prove it.

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